

PURPOSE:

This report will provide the Board with an update of the October 2018 enrollment count and an analysis of trends observed.

DESCRIPTION AND JUSTIFICATION:

A summary of the District's enrollment is as follows:

General Fund Only

Elementary	down	-160 (-1.3%)
Middle	down	-37 (-.6%)
High	up	76 (.8%)
Total K-12	up	-121 (-.4%)

Total Enrollment (including Charters)

Elementary	down	-161 (-1.3%)
Middle	down	-38 (-.52%)
High	up	118 (1.15%)
Total K-12	down	-81 (-.27%)

Not counting Preschool or students housed in outside facilities, overall District enrollment (general fund and charter) is down 81 students in 2018, representing a decline of .3% from last year. Enrollment as of October 3, 2018 stands at 30,201. This year's loss represents significantly lower growth than last year, which posted a gain of .5% (+141). Enrollment change in 2018 represents only the second loss in 13 years, with 2016 also experiencing a similar loss (-64).

Enrollment decline in 2018 was concentrated in the general fund schools which posted a -.4% (-121) loss and significantly underperforming last year's gain of .6%. Charter enrollment experienced a small increase of 40 students, primarily from a rebound in enrollment at Boulder Preparatory High School and increases at Justice High. Otherwise, charter enrollment has been level as most available "seats" at these schools have been consistently filled in recent years.

General fund elementary enrollment posted a fourth year of decline, dropping by -160 students, or -1.3%. This level had experienced a 12 year growth trend peaking in 2010 at 2.4%. However, growth began to weaken in 2011 and started to trend negative in 2015. The prospects for future growth at this level have also narrowed for the foreseeable future as cohort size (enrollment at each grade) has continued to decline. In particular, entering Kindergarten and, to a lesser extent, 1st grade classes have been progressively smaller in recent years.

Kindergarten in 2018 had the smallest enrollment in 14 year at 1,856 students and marked a significant decrease (-67) over the last year's class of 1,923. Along with elementary, kindergarten class size has been trending downward since a peak of 2,113 students in 2011. The resident kindergartener class (those residing within the district boundary) also declined by a similar amount (-65).

Middle school general fund enrollment also experienced decline in 2018 losing 37 students from last year, for a loss of -.6%. Middle school growth was impacted by a smaller incoming 6th grade class that contributed to the decline. Overall, this grade level has been experiencing a leveling in class sizes similar to elementary, and is expected to continue to level and possibly decline in the coming years. Charter enrollment at middle school was on par (-1) with last year's enrollment.

General fund high school enrollment posted the only gains of all grade levels in 2018 increasing by 76 students, or .8% over last year. This gain, however, is modest compared to last year's gain of 224 students and the previous 5 year average of 139 students. The 2018 gain was assisted by a somewhat larger incoming 9th grade class and higher in coming out-of-district open enrollment. As mentioned previously, enrollment expansions at Boulder Preparatory High School and Justice High helped push up charter high school enrollment by 41 students.

Conclusion

Overall BVSD enrollment change was negative in 2018 declining by 81 students, or -.3% from last year, primarily in the general fund schools. This contrasts with last year's gain of 224 students and overall positive growth over the last 13 years. Enrollment in 2016 also posted a similar loss, however.

Enrollment decline in 2018 was focused primarily at the elementary level with middle school also declining to a lesser extent. The elementary decline is a continuation of a leveling and downward trend started in 2015 and was particularly impacted by this year's very small kindergarten class. This current kindergarten class is 67 students smaller than in 2017 and is the smallest class since 2004. The decline at kindergarten is generally consistent with an overall declining birth rate in BVSD and other Front Range communities, but nonetheless was higher than expected. Like other recent kindergarten classes, this class is expected to experience a "pop" in enrollment at first grade next year, but will still likely continue to be a relatively small class as it matriculates through the system. Middle school has also experienced slowing growth in recent years as smaller elementary cohorts' progress to that level, as was the case in 2018.

As stated, high school posted the only enrollment gains in 2018 increasing .8% over last year. However, further review has shown that high school underperformed growth expectations in at least one key area. The number of resident high school students leaving BVSD has been increasing in recent years and peaked in 2018 – a factor that likely constrained high school growth somewhat this year. Also noteworthy was a small decline in the overall out-of-district students enrolled at this level.

Included with this memorandum are a number of enrollment spreadsheets. Staff will also present a brief slide show presentation.